

# Metrical Universals in Oral Poetry

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There has been considerable discussion regarding the various characteristics of orally transmitted poetry, i.e. folkloric poetry in the framework of the oral-formulaic theory and orality-literacy studies. We might assume that the oral method of acquiring, verbalizing and memorizing texts is reflected in the metrics of oral poetry as well, but this question seems to have gained little attention. James Bailey, in his article about Russian folksongs (1995), proposes a list of features that must be taken into account when analyzing a folk song, as opposed to a literary poem. In the present article, I would like to share my observations gathered from my research on the metrics of Estonian folk songs (Sarv 2008) which might contribute to the subject.

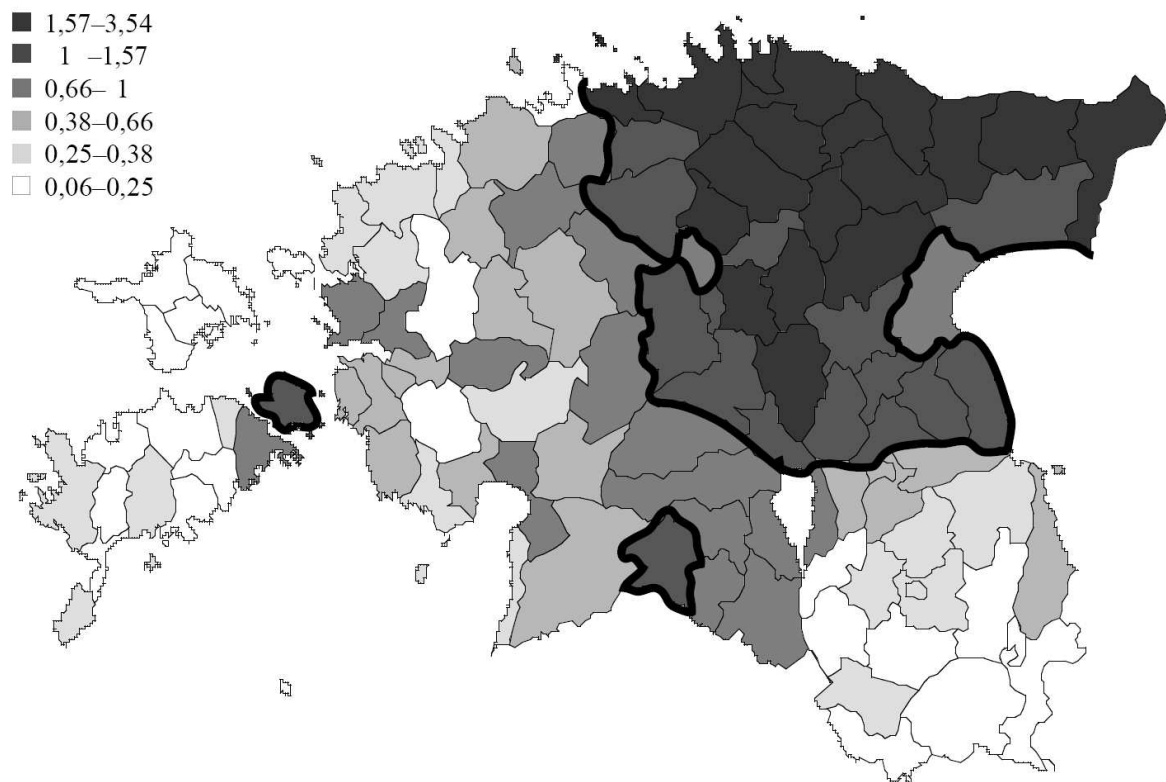
The first question to ask when trying to ascertain the metrical commonalities of oral poetry is, in what way does the metrical constitution of oral poetry differ from literary poetry in the first place? The answer lies in the specifics of folklore – the individual poet has little influence on the poetic form (and oftentimes even on the content) of a traditional oral poem. To some extent this holds true for literary poetry as well, in the framework of literary traditions, and especially when it concerns the borderlines between orality and literacy. An oral poetic system functions in a way that is highly reminiscent of language – it is a natural organic system, wherein a single person has only a modest influence. It has, of course, rules and regularities, but these adapt themselves constantly to various stimuli: language changes, foreign cultural (poetical, musical) influences, factors involved in the performance situation, etc. Similarly to language, the poetic form and the metrics of oral poetry may have dialectal variations, or so-called metrical dialects (cf. Kuusi 1994: 55). It is preserved and transmitted orally and is therefore innovative (adaptive, variable); yet it is also conservative at the same time. Both poles are clearly represented, for instance, in the famous list of characteristics proposed by Walter J. Ong (1982: 36–57) which according to him are generally common to the modes of thinking and verbal expression of oral cultures.

A well-known truth in metrical studies is that versification is dependent upon the prosodic system of the language that the poetry is expressed in. It is quite generally accepted too (this is probably the most common notion about the folkloric meter) that this relationship is of particular consequence in the case of folk poetry (see e. g. Korhonen 1994: 76–78, Lehiste 2000: 38, Noel 2008, Dufter 2003: 195). One may presume that folk poetry, with its entire poetic system, evolved in concert with the language, and thus fits itself optimally to the structure of the language. As Ilse Lehiste puts it: “the prosodic system of a

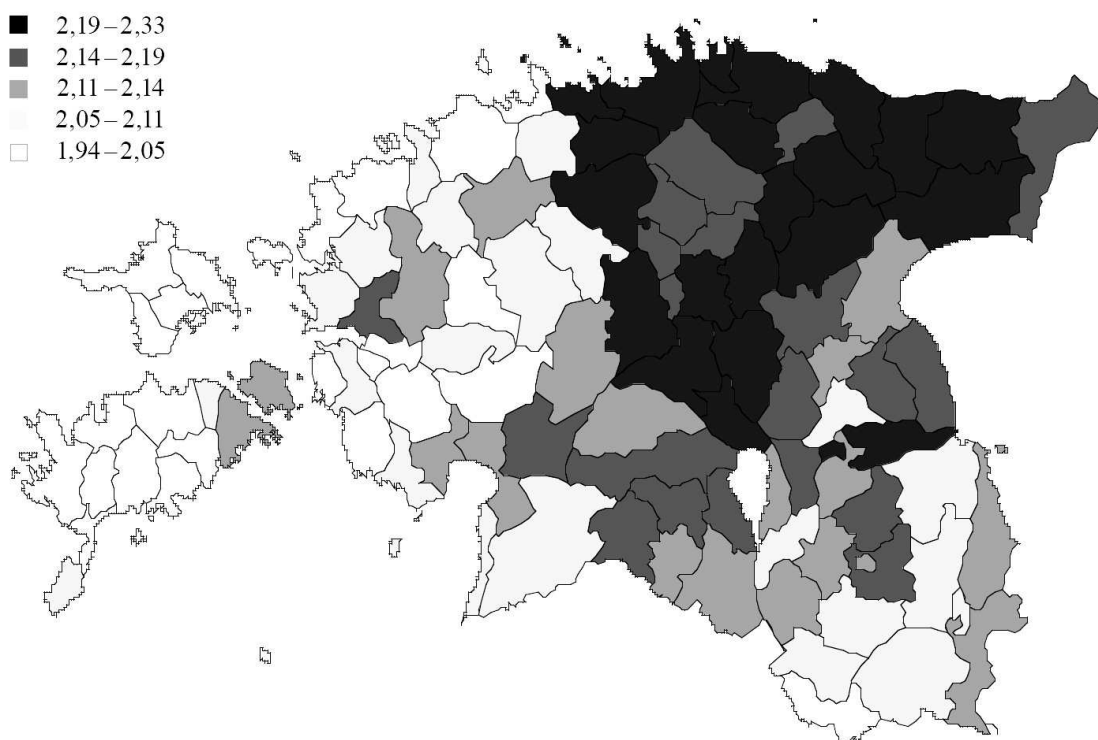
language is crystallized in the metric structure of its traditional poetry” (Ross and Lehiste 2001: 3). In order to demonstrate the manifestation of this relationship and to discuss this crystallization, I would like to make an introductory excursion into the meter of Estonian folk songs.

Older Estonian folk-songs (*regilaul*) belong to a common tradition of several Finnic peoples. The characteristic features of this poetic tradition are a regular (but not regulated) use of alliteration and parallelism and a specific meter, the so-called Kalevala meter (named after the Finnish national epic “Kalevala”, composed on the basis of folk-songs). It is a syllabic meter with a trochaic core, where the position of stressed syllables is regulated according to their quantity. Pentti Leino (1986: 29) has found that the traditional typology of verse systems is not useful when describing the essence of the Kalevala meter, and his preference is to define it as a separate verse-system on its own rather than a syllabic-accentual-quantitative meter with unusual regulations. At the same time – as Pentti Leino (1982: 248) has shown – the Kalevala meter is able to make the most comprehensive use of the Finnish vocabulary, i.e. there are practically no word structures in Finnish that the Kalevala meter cannot employ and there are relatively few of those whose normal frequency of usage is distorted by the Kalevala meter.

Historically, the meter of Estonian folk-songs has clearly relied on the Kalevala meter, but it has also undergone several changes. Significant changes took place in the Estonian language about five hundred years ago – the words were shortened, the quantity system changed, the stressed syllables gained more prominence, etc. (Rätsep 1989). The metrics of folk-songs reflects those changes of the language — the meter is characterized by its being in the transitional stage from the Kalevala meter to a kind of syllabic-accentual meter where quantity opposition between long and short stressed syllables has disappeared; there are, however, significant regional differences. I do not wish to go into details here, but for example when comparing Maps 1 and 2 it is evident that the longer the words are, the more Kalevala-metric (or let us say quantitative) the verses are. The changes in metrics could only have occurred within the past 500 years, following the changes in language. The ongoing process is discernible in the recordings of the last century, and the meter is anything but crystallized. This also means that there are almost no strict rules in the metrics of Estonian folksongs, but rather tendencies.



**Map 1.** The ratio of the count of the verses characteristic of the Kalevala meter to the count of the verses characteristic of the syllabic accentual *regilaul* meter (Sarv 2008:46).



**Map 2.** The average count of syllables of word forms in the regional samples analyzed (Sarv 2008: 87).

One of the essential characteristics of folklore is that a folkloric piece may be renewed with every single performance – some details may be adapted to circumstances, lost parts may be replaced by new wordings, and it may be recomposed in the framework of tradition. This idea is central to oral-formulaic theory (e.g. Lord 2003), and has been encompassed in definitions of folklore (e.g. Honko 1998: 62). This characteristic of ongoing renovation enables the meter to develop in concert with language and keeps it from becoming crystallized.

Another issue I would like to discuss is the relationship between meter and music, or the performance. In the theoretical discussions, the metrical structure of a line or a poem is generally seen as being independent from its (musical) performance – the same text with the same metrical structure can be performed in various ways, and the performance has in itself no influence on the metrical structure of the text (e.g. Jakobson 1988: 46). In the research tradition of Estonian and Finnish folksongs, the literary metricists have admitted this principle (Põldmäe 1978: 22–23, 153–154, Leino 1986: 141–143). Ethnomusicologists, however, emphasize the need to take into account both the meter of the text and the musical meter when analyzing the meter of folk-songs (Sarv 2001: 103–106, Leisiö 2000). Thus, when analyzing a song meter, literary researchers tend to treat it as a text and attempt to discover which patterns have been used to organize the words and the syllables into the lines. Folklorists and ethnomusicologists, on the other hand, endeavour to find out what creates the rhythm of the song as a whole, inasmuch as it constitutes a combination of text, melody and performance.

Although we cannot deny that both, the text and the music, have structures of their own, we likewise cannot ignore the fact that folksongs have evolved and been developed through the symbiosis of text, music and performance. The traditional way of performance and the properties of the melody may have their influence on the form of the text; everything together creates the rhythm in the song as a whole. When analyzing the meter of Estonian folksongs, the reciprocal relationship of text and music appeared to be significant and as a result I have come to the conclusion that metrical and musical templates mutually structure one another.

The relationship between the metrical and the musical structure of line is quite clear-cut in Estonian songs – there are eight musical units corresponding to eight verse positions. As a rule, every musical unit corresponds to one syllable as well, but if there are more or fewer syllables – the number of syllables in a line can span from six to twelve – those syllables must be somehow divided between eight musical or rhythmical units. The recurrent melody with its stable rhythmical division enables us to recognize which units of text the singer perceives as metrically equivalent. From recorded songs we may identify, for example, in which cases one metrical position can be filled with two syllables. The text must

cope with the musical structure, which itself has evolved on the basis of the most common eight-syllabic line.

In the course of the above-mentioned transformational process from the Kalevala meter to the syllabic-accentual *regilaul* meter, some optional licences arose in order to compensate for the gradually disappearing qualities of the former meter and to cope with the various word structures of the language. It became possible to use catalectic verses in the new metrical variants, and the option of filling a verse position with two light syllables became much more viable (this option is quite restricted in the Kalevala meter). But as it is possible for the singers to compose the line following either of the verse systems, and there are no hard and fast rules, the researcher is often presented with several potential ways of dividing the syllables between the verse positions. And in this case, it is only the performance tradition of the region in question that can offer clues as to the metrical division of the texts. For example, the line *mõtelge mehed mõnusad* ‘think, you, nice men’ can be interpreted differently depending on which of the meters the line follows. In the Kalevala metric context, it is divided into the trochaic verse feet as follows:

mõtel/ge me/hed mõ/nusad.

In the syllabic-accentual *regilaul* meter, the word-initial stressed syllables must be matched with the strong positions of the metrical schema and the line is divided (and performed) catalectically, with two quick syllables (underlined) in the first verse position:

mõtel-ge / me-hed / mõ-nu/sad.

In trying to divide the verses according to the two verse systems, it became apparent that there were a great many exceptional verses in the south-east of Estonia. Upon closer examination it turned out that in south-eastern Estonia overlong syllables had developed a specific metrical quality and could fill two verse positions. The line (about a girl preparing a comfortable bed in woodlands to seduce a young man she likes) *ala ta sõkk sõna jala* ‘she trod down the ferns’ could be interpreted as a regular trochaic syllabic-accentual *regilaul* meter:

a-la / ta sõkk / sõ-na/ja-la,

but it is never performed as such. In a traditional South-Estonian performance, the first grammatical word *ala* ‘down’ is again fitted into the first verse position, i. e. performed quickly and the overlong monosyllable *sõkk* ‘trod’ is spread over two verse positions:

a-la ta / sõkk / sõ-na/ja-la.

The next, parallel line *pääle kaib kastõ haina* ‘thereon she gathered and laid some soft hay’ leave no room for a customary interpretation, but follows the traditional South-East-Estonian pattern. Both overlong monosyllables have historically been disyllabic (*sõkk* < \*sõt-ki; *kaib* < \*kai-bi).

To sum up: the boundaries of the metric and music structure most probably coincide at certain points – in artistic music it depends on the decision of the author, but I would propose that in traditional music, if there is a musical recurrence corresponding to the text units, the verse lines, for example, then it is probable that the metrical units have their stable counterparts in the musical structure as well. And this correspondence can in turn give the researchers clues as to how to interpret the metrical structure of a verse in ambiguous cases.

Literary theories of meter have often overlooked the potential role of performance in the shaping of the verse structure; in response Christoph Küper (1988: 274–281) has discussed the beat-based metrical type (*der taktierende Versifikationstyp*) among the other metrical types of the English and German poetical traditions. In the beat-based metrical type, the main characteristic of metrical units is their temporal equality, although the count of syllables may vary. Küper admits that this verse type has been used mostly in ballads and “song-like poems”. The temporal equality seems to function in a similar fashion when considering Estonian folksongs, but it is the verse positions which tend to be equal units and not the beats or feet. Moreover – they need not necessarily be equal, the last position of the verse, for example, can be prolonged or the musical rhythm may have the alternation of long and short units. The most important consideration is that there is a regular correspondence between the two structures (and there are still additional phonological qualities relevant to the metrical structure). I tend to believe that the beat-based metrical type describes only one variant from among the more universal correspondence between metrical and musical structures in various kinds of performed poetry.

Actually, in the case of folksongs, this correspondence between metrical and musical structures is subject to variation as well. Take, for example, the line we just observed, *ala ta sõkk sõnajala*. In a traditional performance the first unit of musical rhythm would correspond to the first disyllabic verse position. One singer recorded in the sixties tends (for the sake of rhythmical variation) to enlarge the melody by one unit in cases when the first trochaic verse-foot has more than two syllables. She even seems to add syllables that are more or less unnecessary to the first verse-foot in order to facilitate this (Oras 2004: 108–109). We cannot say how traditional a rhythmical variation of this kind is, because the *regilaul* tradition had already advanced towards extinction from everyday use and, in addition, there are few recordings from the same time period and region. This example, however, once again, nicely characterizes the variability of folklore.

There is one more feature, which is fundamentally present in Estonian folksongs, and might be characteristic of oral versification more generally, in those cases where we have to do with a genuine and continuous metrical tradition. A characteristic feature of the Estonian *regilaul* is that it has systematically retained archaic grammatical word-forms. Contemporary word-

forms usually have fewer syllables, and thus older forms have been preserved in traditional lines which have maintained the traditional wording, or these have been kept as the components of various formulae and also as support for the metrical needs of newly composed lines. The longer, archaic word forms can readily be used next to the more contemporary grammatical forms, but they help to keep the trochaic structure of a line more coherent (as a rule the monosyllables are metrically neutral in Estonian folksongs), and some grammatical forms and word structures are particularly useful for coping with the regularities of the Kalevala meter – so the old syllable number of words and the traditional verse structure can both be maintained. In analyzing the metrics of Russian folksongs, James Bailey (1993) has described a functionally similar use of historical word forms – in Russian folksongs the position of word stress as well as the syllable count of words are varied for metrical reasons. In both cases the word forms from different historical layers of language are systematically and flexibly used in order to overcome the metrical constraints.

My research on Estonian folksongs allows me to suggest that historical assimilation processes are crucial for changes in the metrical traditions. We may suppose that the ability of foreign (assimilating) people to acquire the creative use of archaic word forms is quite limited, thus as a consequence of this, oral poetry loses some of its historical expressions, and the meter's process of adjusting to the contemporary language is accelerated.

At this point I would like to return to Bailey's list of features that according to him must be taken into account when analyzing folk songs (Bailey 1995: 488–489) and also further comment upon its validity when considering Estonian folksongs.

- 1) there is a fundamental difference between a fixed, written text and a variable, oral text;
- 2) the study of folk verse requires a thorough knowledge of the poetic idiom in folk songs, particularly syllabification and accentuation;
- 3) as for the quality of folk song recordings, rhythmical analysis should be based only on the most reliable collections;
- 4) works of ethnomusicology should be considered because they offer information on the relationship between the musical and verbal rhythms and on how music produces repetition in the verbal text;
- 5) a number of variants of a given song should be examined to determine the prevailing meter;
- 6) since genres play a role in the formation of folk songs in regard to performance mode and social function, the genre associations of each meter should be delineated.

The main ideas of the first four points in Bailey's list are undoubtedly relevant when considering Estonian folk songs as well – the importance of the variability in folklore has already been explained on several occasions. Likewise the

knowledge of historical language and the traditional way of performance is of relevance in order to appropriately analyze the metrical structure of the text. The necessity of taking into account the correspondences between the units of metrical and musical structure was also one of the concerns in the present paper.

Bailey's points 5 and 6 are not relevant to older Estonian folk songs. The *regilaul* meter has a remarkable degree of regional variation (as has the language), but apart from that, it is not possible to distinguish the relevance of any other kind of metrical variation. The regional properties clearly override those of one song or song-type, even those of the song-genres and the individuality of singers. In the case of Estonian songs, the only significant variation in the meter in addition to the regional variation is the temporal one.

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